

THE OPENING SHOT .

A SPECIALTY COFFEE JOURNAL — WRITTEN, BREWED & OVER-ANALYSED BY HARISH
JANUARY — JULY 2026 · SINGAPORE / UBUD / MUMBAI / JOHOR BAHRU

Forty cups.
One benchmark.
Zero milk.

This is not a coffee blog. It is a field journal — six months of filter coffee, logged with extraction physics, thermal phase notes and varietal genetics, then translated back into plain language. Inside: the cup that reset my palate, the morning of two archive firsts before noon, the case against conical brewers, and a seven-year-old's first tasting note.

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40

entries

21

cafés

15

origin countries

180

days

SGD 265.95

documented spend

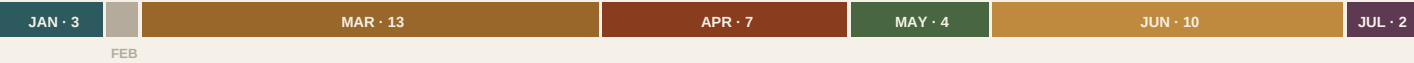
"The cup is never just a cup."

The Journey

Six months, four cities, and an archive that refused to stay small.



SESSION INTENSITY BY MONTH



JAN

The accidental beginning

UBUD, BALI

A family holiday, a rice-field café, and a Kintamani Natural I ordered without thinking. Three cups at Seniman later, I was typing brew ratios into my phone at the breakfast table. The archive had begun before I'd agreed to it.

FEB

One cup, one signal

SINGAPORE

A single February entry: Kenya Kiamugumo AA at Kyuukei. SL28/SL34, fully washed — that phosphoric acid grip that coats the palate and refuses to leave. A genetic signature, not a roast trick. Quiet month, loud cup.

MAR

Thirteen cups, one apricot

MUMBAI + SINGAPORE

The busiest month, and the most personal. Mumbai's anaerobic lots felt polite; Singapore answered with conviction. At Narrative, Aanya tasted her first specialty filter — a Salvadoran Natural — and said 'apricot' before I'd said anything. It went straight into the archive. Some entries are data. That one is memory.

APR

The Holy Trinity closes

SINGAPORE + JOHOR

La Laja's washed Sudan Rume opened the month with nectarine precision. A Panama Geisha followed at Lume in the rain. Then Asylum, with Aanya, and the Peru Gesha that completed the set: Gesha, Wush Wush, Sudan Rume — all washed, all in five weeks, none of it planned. April ended across the border: Hacienda La Florida in Johor, MYR 35, lime hot and plum cool. The furthest I've travelled for a single cup.

MAY

Nylon, four ways

SINGAPORE

Two days, four cups, one roaster. Two Brazils playing opposite games, an Ethiopia Banko Gotiti that moved lemon → melon → white tea as it cooled, and a Nicaraguan anaerobic that tasted like none of them. Nylon doesn't hedge. It's why I keep going back — five visits now, the most of any café in the archive.

JUN

The acceleration

SINGAPORE

Ten entries in nineteen days, and the morning I won't forget: Sunday the 28th, Keryi at 10:30 for a Mosto Fermentation — a process first — then Asylum by 11:06 for the Yellow Sudan Rume EF2. Two archive firsts before noon. En route, June also delivered the archive's first Liberica: longan on the nose, vinyl records on the walls, nothing else like it in forty cups.

JUL

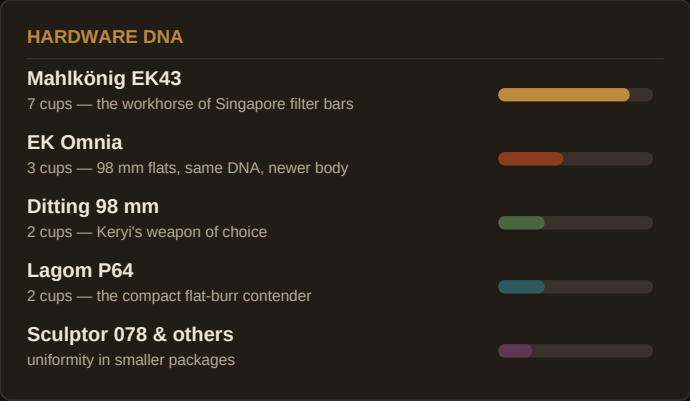
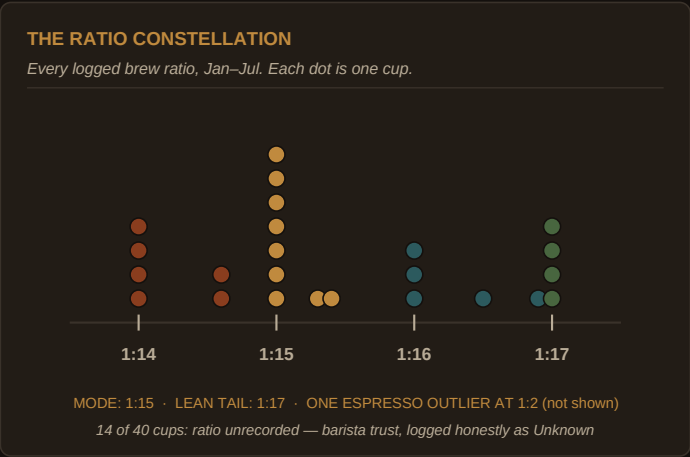
Closing the half

SINGAPORE

H1 refused a quiet ending. June 30: the first Myanmar entry — and the first cup dispensed from an automated tap, logged N/A for brew parameters because there was no brew event to record. July 1: Kyuukei's Ethiopia Worka Chelchele, a landrace triad brewed on a ramped 85→95°C profile. Forty entries. The ledger closes; the palate doesn't.

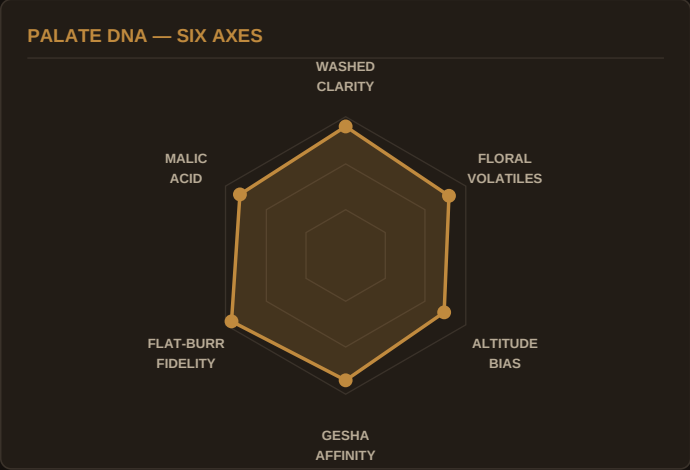
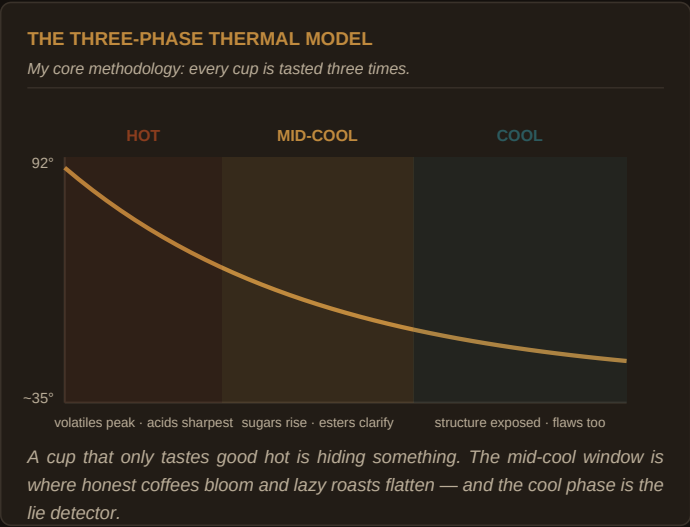
The Palate Laboratory

Where the geekery lives: burr geometry, brew ratios, and the three-phase thermal model.



GEEK SIDEBAR — WHY FLAT BURRS?

Flat burrs cut; conicals crush. Cutting produces a tighter particle distribution — fewer boulders under-extracting, fewer fines clogging the bed. In the cup, that reads as **clarity**: each volatile compound arrives distinct instead of smeared. 95% of my logged sessions ran flat burrs, and the two worst cups of the half were both conical-brewer drawdowns choked by fines. The data is small. The pattern is not.



DOSE · YIELD · TEMPERATURE

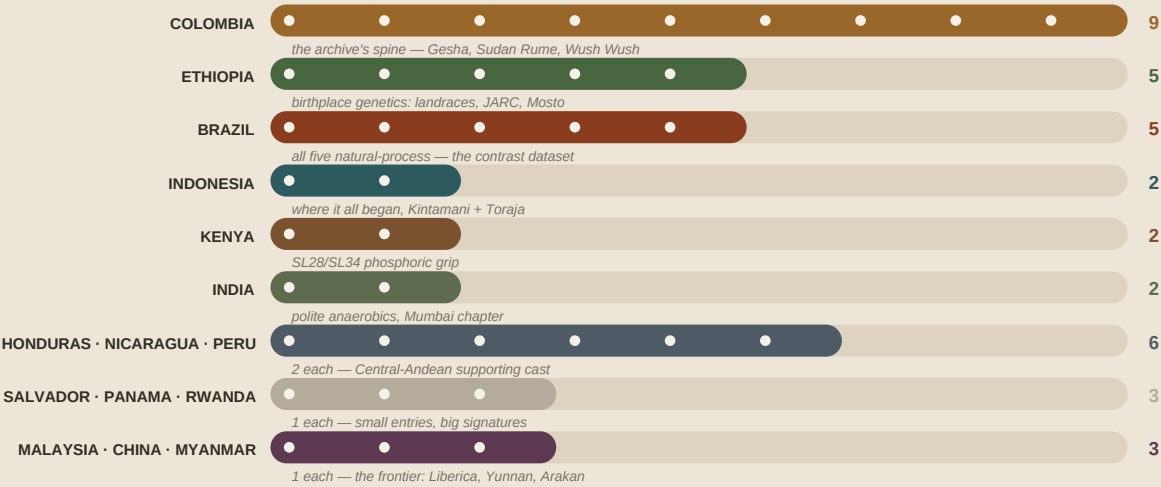
Standard dose	15 g	the archive default
Yield window	190–277 g	across confirmed pours
Temp protocols	91–95°C · 91→78°C · 85→95°C ramp	the schools, one palate
The wildest	90–92° pours 1-2, 68–70° pours 3-4	the split-thermal Orea recipe

The Origin Atlas

Fifteen countries passed through one palate. Here is what the map looks like.

THE FREQUENCY TABLE

Cups per origin country · Jan–Jul 2026 · pips mark individual sessions



THE ALTITUDE LADDER

Highest to lowest — every MASL tells you what acids to expect.



THE PROCESS LEDGER

How the cherry was treated before it reached me.



FIELD NOTE — THE MYANMAR MOMENT

Entry #39 was a frontier twice over: the archive's first Myanmar origin — a Catimor from the Arakan Mountains — and its first cup poured from an automated batch tap. Pear-forward, almond edge, faithful to the roaster's notes... and completely flat across the thermal phases. No hot-to-cool journey, because batch dispensing erases the brew event itself. Logged with parameters marked N/A — not missing data, but a format that has no parameters to give. The atlas grows in strange directions.

The Benchmark Gallery

Three cups, decoded phase by phase. This is what my methodology is actually for.

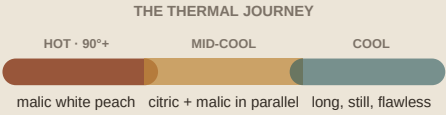
Nº 1

THE ALL-TIME BENCHMARK

EL OBRAJE

Fluid Collective · Washed Colombia Gesha · Cauca

The cup every other Gesha now answers to. What made it singular wasn't intensity — it was **integration**. Most washed Colombians lead citric; El Obraje led malic, softer and rounder, and then refused to collapse as it cooled. In the mid-cool window the two acids ran in parallel like harmony lines, neither dominating. The cool phase — my lie detector — found nothing to expose. A benchmark isn't a score. It's a cup you cannot stop measuring against.



■ GEEK NOTE
Extraction read: complete acid integration suggests even bed extraction + tight particle distribution — flat-burr signature all over it.

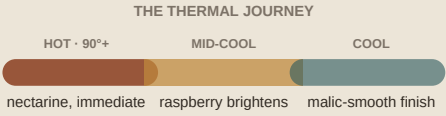
Nº 2

THE VARIETAL REVELATION

LA LAJA — JAMES FERNANDEZ

Maxi Coffee Bar · Washed Sudan Rume · Cauca, Colombia

Sudan Rume is a wild Ethiopian variety that most farms refuse to grow — the yields punish you. James Fernandez grows it anyway, and Maxi served it on a CBD lunch break with quiet confidence. The first sip wasn't fruity-adjacent; it was **actually nectarine** — the specific one, not the category. Then raspberry underneath, then the textbook dual-acid handoff: citric on top, malic closing. First washed Sudan Rume in the archive, and the cup that set the Holy Trinity in motion.



■ GEEK NOTE
SSP 78 mm flat burrs at 1:15 — precision hardware for a precision varietal. The clarity was earned twice: in the field and at the grinder.

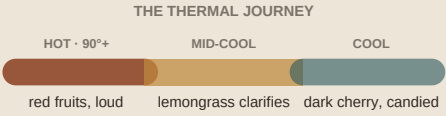
Nº 3

THE PROCESS MILESTONE

YELLOW SUDAN RUME EF2

Asylum Coffeehouse · Extended Fermentation Natural · Pijiao, Quindío

The second cup of the two-firsts morning. A yellow mutation of Sudan Rume put through Extended Fermentation — a process that deliberately prolongs what nature starts, coaxing geraniol and lemongrass esters to the surface. The phases behaved like three different coffees: red-fruit riot hot, herbal clarity mid, then concentrated dark cherry that flirted with candy without crossing into it. Processing as authorship. Some cups you plan for. This one I just showed up for.



■ GEEK NOTE
EF2 esters are thermally fragile — the lemongrass note only exists in a ~15°C window. Without three-phase tasting, you'd simply never meet it.

Field Notes & The Road Ahead

What forty cups taught me — and what the next forty are for.

Washed isn't boring. It's honest.

The archive kept confirming what I suspected: washed process is where terroir, genetics and altitude speak without a translator. A washed Gesha at 2,100 MASL tastes like the mountain. Naturals are fireworks; washed is the night sky behind them.

The conical problem is now data.

Two sessions, same signature: V60 geometry, fines pooling at the drain, citric flatness, no thermal journey. The identical coffee on a flat-bottom bed told a different story. Flat burrs, flat bottom — no longer a preference. A finding.

The best entries aren't about coffee.

Aanya's 'apricot' at Narrative — called before I said a word — outranks every technical note I took this half. She ordered a second cup at Asylum in April without prompting. The archive logs coffee. Some rows log more.

Logging changes drinking.

You slow down. You wait for the mid-cool. You clock the barista's grinder before the menu. Forty cups in, I taste in three tenses — what the cup is, was, and is about to become. That's the real return on the archive.

THE H2 HIT LIST

- Eugenioides**
the near-mythical diploid — barely any caffeine, absurd sweetness
- Homeground Experience Room**
tasting-lab format, champion pedigree, embarrassingly overdue
- Glyph Supply Co · Jurong**
farm-specific tasting menu — a barista tip I still owe a visit
- Oaks Coffee Co**
Jervis Tan, 2025 National Barista Champion. Enough said.
- Tokyo & Melbourne**
the first expansion beyond this region's gravity

H1 — THE LEDGER

Total documented spend	SGD 265.95
Average per session	SGD 10.23
Cheapest cup	SGD 5.10 — Kyuukei Kenya
Priciest	MYR 35 (~SGD 11) — Johor
Most-visited café	Nylon — five sessions
Flat-burr sessions	95% of known hardware
Milk drinks in the audit	zero, and counting
Archive firsts logged	9 — species, process, format

UNTIL THE CLOSING SHOT

Issue 02 arrives at year-end, covering July through December. I don't know what it will hold — that's the point. If you know a café, a bean, or a producer that belongs in the archive, tell me. The best cups in this issue all started as someone else's recommendation. — Harish, Singapore, July 2026